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Curiosity and the Fear of the Unknown

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1. Introduction

Hanne De Jaegher (2019) lays the groundwork for a more engaged epistemology through which the epistemic process can be understood as a dynamic, mutual relation of determination, in analogy to loving. Her approach is built on the enactive theory of participatory sense-making, according to which the relation between epistemic agent and environment is primordially imbued with significance and value, and further shaped through intersubjective processes.

One of the core issues regarding this approach is the internal structure of the epistemic agent. In what way does a dynamic epistemic relation of that kind present itself to them, what criteria do they apply to determine the right amount of determination, and why would they do it?

A neuralgic point is the moment an epistemic agent is confronted with something or someone significantly new and unknown. Every entity must necessarily appear as radically unknown if it is to disclose a distinct individuality. Success hinges on the epistemic agent's ability to recognize that individuality and to not immediately subsume them under preexisting concepts. The affective structure of such encounters is crucial to understand them.

In this text, I want to contribute to the discussion on an engaged epistemology by analyzing the process through which epistemic agents appreciate the individuality of their epistemic counterpart and are provided motivation to explore it, or develop techniques to obliterate it. In particular, I will focus on the handling of the unknown, the emotional response to it, and the regulation of action towards it.

In a first section, I will outline the enactivist theory of affectivity and cognition and the self-umwelt distinction.

In a second section, I will investigate the unknown as an intentional object of consciousness. Curiosity will be examined as a positive emotional alignment towards the unique, and the fear of the unknown as its negation.

In a final part, I will relate my findings to De Jaegher's theory, and give a further perspective on the shared structure between knowing and loving.

2. The enactivist Theory of affectivity and the self-umwelt relation

As living beings, humans are primordially determined to distinguish themselves from their environment by establishing a self and evaluate their environment to motivate action to prevent its disintegration. This perspective forms the baseline of the enactivist theory of mind and affectivity that De Jaegher's model is based on (cf. Colombetti 2010). The basis of this theory is the notion of an "intrinsic teleology" (Weber/Varela 2002) in living organisms that goes out from the living body (Leib) and forms a subjective perspective.

From the point of view that is taken by self-organisation of the organism, a proto-evaluation of the environment takes place. It is made sense of as an *umwelt*, a space of tools and possible action that gains its significance in relation to the self. The theory postulates a continuity between life and mind; cognition and affectivity are not seen as separate systems, but as aspects of one continuous process of evaluation and "active homeostasis" (cf. Di Paolo 2005), with an emphasis on adaptivity. From the perspective of this theory, an explanation is needed as to how the quality of being unknown found in the *umwelt* can be interpreted as an extension of the self rather than a threat of disintegration.

The enactive model as sketched above does not give a description of the phenomenology of specific emotions and the internal perspective of the subject. To extend De Jaegher's account of the epistemic relation, it is fruitful to integrate this internal perspective.

A good model for the *function* of emotions is lined out by Jean-Paul Sartre (2014). He establishes a distinction between the thematic object of consciousness, upon which we reflect, and the non-thematic structure of consciousness which makes up the way in which we apprehend the intentional object without being itself an object of reflection. In action as well as emotion, we are not *reflectively* aware of the self, but of the world as *umwelt*.

As part of the structure of consciousness, emotions are means to change the way the world presents itself *through our feeling body*. The world usually is apprehended in the context of action. Emotions come into play when action towards the world is *too difficult*. Through emotion, an otherwise deterministic world is “magically” transformed in such a way that, while structurally identical, its qualities change to enable action (or inaction).

An emphasis needs to be put on the bodily nature of emotion and the role of the body in regards to the structure of intentionality. Firstly, feelings are integrated in the way intentional objects are given. They are part of the content as well as the evaluation of the object (Goldie 2002). In the phenomenal structure, emotion and intentional object form an inseparable unity, and the body can be seen as a vehicle through which a subject is in the world, and through which it is evaluated (Slaby 2007). Emotions can be characterized as “felt evaluations” (Helm 2002). In the description of the intentional structure of an emotion, a differentiation can be made between its *target*, which is the concrete object it is directed at, its *formal object*, which is the quality as which it is evaluated, and its *focus*. The focus is the value, or object of import, for the sake of which the evaluation is made (ibid.).

Secondly, feelings are also part of the underlying structure through which experience is fundamentally shaped and that makes intentional emotions possible. Ratcliffe (2005) illustrates how feelings form part of the way one finds oneself in the world. He argues that there are “existential feelings”, bodily feelings which are usually unconscious and make up the structure of world-relatedness and self-world distinction. They are not themselves intentional, but form part of the basis of intentionality. Existential feelings “determine the space of experiential possibilities”(ibid.). A feeling of being distanced and alienated from the world, for example, would impede emotions of engagement and the import of the reality of consequences. Existential feelings will play an important role in my analysis of curiosity and the fear of the unknown.

A distinction between primitive forms of life and their umwelt-relation and human beings lies in their non-thematic and non-reflective self-awareness through the

role of an *ego* as a condition for the unity of experience as well as their ability to abstractly represent their self as a self-image and thematically reflect on it. As a result of this, the autopoietic process is severely complicated, and along with it the evaluation of the environment. A conflict may arise between aspects of selfhood. The unknown, which represents no utility in the *umwelt* of any fixed self, becomes significant in the context of the ability to provide a unification of these aspects. This ability manifests itself through curiosity as an affect that directs consciousness towards the unknown and to evaluate it positively.

3. The epistemic access to the unknown

One of the main problems that needs to be addressed if the possibility of a non-predetermined epistemological relation is to be made plausible, is in what way the unknown and unique can be apprehended by consciousness and be part of its intentional object. I presume that there is no viable notion of a material, objective mental *image* of the unknown; it is not possible to possess a *universal concept* of “unknownness” that could ground a purely rational judgment. Such a concept could not contain any stable, positive, internal features of unknown objects, could not give a criterion for its application, and would therefore be empty.

The unknown is not positively given. It only appears to the subject *as part of an action* in the context of an otherwise fully conceptually structured, deterministic world as an “empty space”. There is always something about which circumstances are unknown. The source may lie in the confrontation with something radically new, in an unsolvable aporetic problem (Candiotto 2019), in the sudden realization of an argumentative gap etc. The initial appearance is therefore an instance of rational judgment, but this judgment only determines it negatively. I intend to show that the phenomenon of the unknown itself is separate from this initial judgment and cannot be explained as one, but rather through the feeling body as a vessel of agency.

If the irritation is vast and strong enough to challenge the whole conceptual world in its entirety, the resulting emotion is disorientation which is grounded in the

feeling of not knowing how to act (Earnshaw 2019). If it is contained as a distinct occurrence in an otherwise stable world on the other hand, consciousness *is bound* to direct itself at the “empty space” and engage in an action to deal with it.

3.1 The instrumental relation to the unknown

In probably the vast majority of epistemic activity, the motivation to act comes from something external to the unknown object. It might consist of a technical purpose, the feeling of satisfaction derived from success in problem-solving, etc. In this type of constellation, the quality at which consciousness directs itself, and the formal object of its evaluation, is never the unknown *as unknown*. It only appears as resistance to the success of the goal of the overall task, and phenomenally as a non-reflected structure of the action. It is of course possible to reflect on the structure of the problem, but this reflection is only concerned with the abstract, logical problem and does not arouse emotion. The unknown only appears as not-yet-known or not-yet- solved. As *resistance*, it can still give rise to frustration or increase to satisfaction of successful puzzle-solving, but these emotions relate to the success of the action and not the content of the unknown object. The epistemic success as measured by the instrumental value of the acquired knowledge is not affected by this, and therefore there is nothing in the structure of the action that would limit the agent in solving the problem in the most deflationary and reductive way possible.

As long as the relation to the unknown remains an instrumental one, it remains pre-structured by the intended purpose of the subject. The object does not get space to announce itself in its individuality, and any such announcement could only be perceived as resistance and evaluated negatively by the subject. If an approach that lets the object be in its unpredictable uniqueness is to succeed, there needs to be a human ability to engage with the unknown in a different way. This requires an element that interrupts the continuous engagement in instrumental projects and orients consciousness towards the unknown as an object of import. Such an element can be found in the feelings of awe and curiosity.

3.2 Curiosity as the positive relation to the unknown

The structure of a non-instrumental epistemic relation must consist in an initial moment of awe which is followed by a time of emotion that retains the quality of the initial awe and integrates it into action through motivation. After this analysis, awe and curiosity share a common principle that enables the epistemic agent to relate themselves to the condition of facing the unknown in a positive way. As the instrumental relation is reductive, unbiased epistemic action is necessarily emotional. In the following, I will argue for this necessity.

It can be presumed that all the aspects that occur in the phenomenon of an emotion occur with necessity. None can be isolated without losing their significance. Therefore, any explanation must satisfy all of them through a unified principle. The following aspects are characteristics of curiosity:

1. Through curiosity, consciousness is directed at a distinct object with the phenomenal quality of being unknown.
2. Curiosity motivates explorative action towards the object.
3. The motivation is directed at one object specifically and particularly. It cannot shift to a replacement.
4. It is directed at the intrinsic character of the target. The agent is moved to dissolve the unknown towards the least reductive solution.
5. Curiosity has “positive” hedonic valence.

Curiosity is oftentimes seen as a purely positive emotion, or, in the case of wonder, as an ambivalent emotion combining pleasure and the uneasiness and anxiety of facing aporetic states as motivation to move beyond them (Candiotto 2019). In many views, the motivational force of curiosity is explained through its hedonic valence *alone*. While I agree that curiosity is positively valenced, I believe the positive and negative relation to the unknown to be distinct, separable phenomena with different causal structures. Overall, explanation needs to be done as to how and *why* these relations are hedonically valenced.

The critical point lies in the specificity of the object of curiosity. In the traditional view, the expectation of pleasure or pain, as desire, connected to an object, as motivation to act, lacks this specificity. The motivation is based on a *preexisting*, latent desire on the side of the subject that gets actualised by a specific occurrence, providing a suitable target. As a result of that, the object of desire can be replaced if a different one enters the picture that is superior in quantity or more accessible. Ultimately, the internal, private feeling is the goal of the motivated action, even if in the state of desire it is feeling towards a different target. The relationship remains instrumental¹. Therefore, theories that explain motivation through the internal feelings alone cannot explain curiosity.

Motivation through emotion is generally more complex. Using Helm's conceptual model, the intentional structure of curiosity can be analysed in more detail. The target of curiosity seems to be the "empty space" of the unknown and the context through which it is given and becomes significant. However, not every such occurrence triggers curiosity. The unknown can also be neglected or cause fear as a completely antithetic emotional response. Stating that the formal object of curiosity is unknownness does not seem to elucidate much. It seems necessary to clear up what the focus is to make the formal object intelligible.

Given the characteristics of the unknown, it seems implausible that the focus would be the concrete truth about the unknown state of affairs, understood as correspondence with the factual reality², as it does not have any significance or value in itself. In the sequence of action, a preexisting interest would still need to be connected to the truth-bearer to explain its motivating force. A better candidate is the activity of exploration itself and its performance. However, attention has to be paid as to which specific aspect of the activity is valued here. It cannot be the pure intellectual achievement or general intellectual "desire for movement". If that were the case, it could equally be quenched for formal activities (e.g. playing

1 It is also dubious how the expectation of pleasure towards the unknown would be acquired or represented, given that there is no universal concept of it.

2 Given the underdetermination of the unknown, this would require an account of "inostensible concepts" whose reference is sought through curiosity. Such a view is defended by Inan (2012, p.34ff), although of curiosity as a non-emotional state of mind

chess) or through fantasy and would not depend on any *specific* target, or be concerned with the *reality* of the target.

The problem of curiosity lies in finding an element that necessitates the connection of a general, subjective activity with a specific, concrete object, in spite of the fact that this object is unknown and has no properties that would make it relevant for any specific activity or interest. Neither the isolated subject nor the isolated object explain the specific connection present in curiosity. The solution can only be found in their conjunction. The formal relation and existential condition of *being in the world itself* is being apprehended through curiosity. The focus is a specific notion of selfhood: being a dynamic, effective and active force in the world.

To rise to this feeling, the subject must first be confronted with an object that is fit to reflect its activity in this way, and break out of the chain of instrumental projects. This is performed by the feeling of awe. The most fitting description of this initial amazement is given by Immanuel Kant through his analysis of the dynamically sublime (KdU B 102-113).

In Kant's view, this feeling is aroused in the face of the overwhelming force and *vastness* of nature, which is considered as threatening. It however does not consist of fear, but in a certain kind of self-evaluation and confidence: the subject judges its own value to be independent of the physical goods and harm to the (physical) body that are in peril. Rather, it evaluates itself through the feeling of the sublime as a subject of practical ideas of reason that surpass the situation in the physical realm. Kant further theorizes that this feeling usually requires cultivation.

While Kant's account I based on metaphysical and psychological assumptions that cannot be discussed in this text, the core idea provides a good model for the felt evaluation that is given through curiosity. The subject distinguishes itself from being externally determined in projects of instrumental reason and evaluates itself not through a fixed self-image, but as a dynamic subject of action and thought. I understand the self-relation expressed in Kant's approach to be dialectic: it does not consist in a simple negation of the physical situatedness of the subject, but

emphasizes the unity of the subject in which the body is seen as a condition and structural element of the evaluation³. However, in Kant's view, the sublime is mostly encountered in nature and rather auratic. It does not motivate as much to act or explore as to stand still and marvel, and is not tied to a specific object that could appear in the context of action.

A central feature of consciousness is the activity of idealization, the conversion of reality into ideas and thought. It is the basis of the epistemic process. Subjective activity and consciousness of it is only possible in so far as it is limited⁴ by the objective world. To be aware of oneself as the subject of an action *in reality*, there needs to be a limitation against which the action is performed. Otherwise, there would be no discrepancy between idea and fulfillment, no process of action, no consciousness. If, on the other hand, activity were universally limited, no action would be possible. Only in the context of being limited by individual objects through tie is it possible to be aware of oneself as an acting subject. In confrontation with one object in its specificity, the agent expands their understanding of the worldliness of their actions. The agent *wants* to be limited, wants to find a counterpart that resists them.

The function of curiosity is therefore enabling action towards the unknown and expression of a felt positive evaluation of an existential condition. It can only serve that function directed at the unknown, dispersing it towards finding a worldly counterpart that is desired to be flourishing and unique. An object that is fully known condemns the subject to passivity in regard to its subjective freedom, action is only possible in the context of an external goal. The unknown does not provide any usefulness to any such goal. It resists being used as a tool. The world becomes difficult as the radical independence of the real world of the subjective consciousness shows itself. The quality of unknownness makes salient the idea that there is a structure to a thing that I *do not determine*.

3 This view would be consistent with Kant's view on the living body (Leib) in the *Opus Posthumum*(cf. Weber/Varela 2002)

4 This notion is very loosely based on Schelling(1992). I cannot argue for the validity of this approach in this text.

Curiosity solves the problem of confronting the unknown by enabling action: by presenting the unknown itself as alluring, the subject can overcome self-reflection and act. In the phenomenon of the unknown, the self-image through which the environment is evaluated to the standard of self-conservation is *negated*. The resistance of the world that is represented by the unknown is reinterpreted as connecting activity and world and signifying free agency. Through explorative action, the subject can integrate the unknown into the Umwelt to a self if that self is modified in such a way to allow such integration.

After analyzing the integrative character of curiosity, it can be made more clear in what way it is grounded in the notion of a lived body. A purely rational, concept-based approach to the unknown could achieve as little as one purely through internal feelings, as no rational judgment could connect anything to the unknown as such. A condition for its possibility is a foregoing structure of existential feelings. The subject must feel to be an active agent in an approachable and tangible world to be capable of curiosity. This feeling of agency is a structural part in the unity of the aspects of the self through the constitution as one acting, living body. The act of intentionality that constitutes curiosity is an evaluation of the *process* of living and sense-making, not of any particular state of its substrate or instrument of action. Therefore, there needs to be a unifying element foregoing and pre-structuring the phenomenon. This is found in the underlying feeling of agency.

The presence of such a foregoing (existential) feeling can also explain the difference between instances of curiosity and instances of disinterest or fear. The importance of the feeling of agency can best be elucidated through its negation: if the subject does not trust its agency, the unknown becomes scary.

3.3 The Fear of the Unknown

As much as curiosity is a feeling of widening, openness to the world and fluidity, its negation, the fear of the unknown, is connected to constriction, disengagement and fixation.

Fear of the unknown needs to be distinguished from another form of fear which I will call, in lack of a better term, fear of the dark. It is also evoked in the face of a somewhat underdetermined world, however the mechanism is more alike to fantasy: something scary is imagined on the canvass of the underdetermined world, like monsters under the bed, and the implications of this scary thing are what is being feared. This requires some sort of foregoing fascination with the scary object, probably as a result of having a vague idea of a potential threat but not possessing knowledge as to when and how direct it can affect a subject. It is therefore most common in children, who cannot estimate how real monsters are, and victims of traumatic violence whose confidence in the stability of a secure environment is shaken. While the fear of the dark is some form of explorative behavior, this text is only concerned with fear directed at the unknown as such.

By occupying oneself in their everyday projects, agents acquire trusted patterns of strategies to accomplish fulfillment of recurring basic needs and to manage their affective state. They even integrate their environment in their activities and shape it to accommodate and enhance their cognitive processes (Sterelny 2010) and affect regulation (Colombetti et Krueger 2015). This results in an externalisation of agency through the use of cognitive tools. An important feature of this habituation is the *individualisation* of such cognitive tools. Through frequent use, cognitive tools can become so entrenched into the pattern of successive affective regulation that they cease to be regarded as external tools and grow into extensions of the pragmatic body, part of the self. A good example for such an entrenched case would be (civilian) gun carriers: having initially acquired and carried the gun to calm (probably diffuse) fears, after some time the carriers may

start to feel anxiety when they do not carry them in public, in spite of the fact that *no discernible danger is present*. The gun will then further shape behavior and proliferate fear.

It is in the moment of facing a glimpse of the unknown that the individualisation of tools and habituation of patterns transforms the world to be scary. As much as the unknown gets signified by the context of the known, the unknown can be interpreted as threatening only in a context of fixed structures of the self. The difficulty is solved by transforming the world to reassure the static self-image. It is imagined *as if it was unilaterally structured by the subject* according to its self-image. The actual, unique structure of the object is disregarded.

The way in which the unknown is eliminated from reflective consciousness through fear can take multiple forms. Through repression, the unknown is simply excluded from consciousness. More relevant for the topic at hand are other mechanisms. If a need for knowledge is unavoidable, the object of inquiry is transformed to fit within the subject's foregoing structure of knowledge acquisition, and the norms of truth and justification are warped with them. An insufficient justification is treated as if it was convincing through affective affirmation, a dubious truth is fixed through force of conviction⁵.

In summary, curiosity and the fear of the unknown are antithetically structured. Through curiosity, the static self is negated and the specificity of the object allowed to unfold. In the fear of the unknown, the object is negated and the specificity of the self fixed.

⁵ As such conviction is highly fit to enable further action, it is often integrated into new patterns, cognitive tools or social arrangements.

4. The shared principle of Loving and Knowing

In De Jaegher's(2019) critique of the traditional concepts of knowing and knowledge, she draws a parallel between loving and knowing and proposes that both share a core that needs to be rediscovered and reintegrated into our practices of knowledge acquisition. In her view, knowing relations should consist in dynamic, mutual relationships that allow both the knower and the known to avoid being over-determined by the other. The core idea is to "let the other be", which De Jaegher conceives of non as a form of disconnection, but of engagement, in a way that lets the other remain in its concrete ipseity.

“(...)what happens in loving is not neutral. The lover is not general or universal. They are not an abstract subject. Quite the opposite. In loving, who loves matters. The lover is particular and concrete. Loving goes out from a person's core being (...) This also goes for the one who is loved: it is this particular one that one loves (...) One cannot love abstractly”(De Jaegher 2019).

Following my analysis, it can be seen how the emotions of curiosity and love relate to each other in respect to the topic at hand. Both are founded on comparable existential feelings and emotions and work through a similar principle.

Love also begins with an initial moment of awe in which the loved breaks out of the succession of tokens of the generalized other and unveils their unique personality. Love, however, is specifically directed at other rational beings that appear as individual autonomous agents, which necessarily entails unknownness and unpredictability. Lovers as well need to be receptive to the opportunity by constituting their self in such a way that this unknown uniqueness has a chance to appear in their umwelt. The positive emotional evaluation is shared by curiosity and love: it is true in a literal sense of the word that loved ones are wonder-ful. The quality in which self-actualisation is offered through love is, however, much more directly connected to mutual recognition, intersubjectivity and moral agency, the implications of which cannot be explored in this text.

The assumption that “Each participant in the loving relationship attempts to maintain their identity, their ipseity, in the face of their coming together. “(De Jaegher 2019) does not describe the phenomenon accurately. Were they concerned with their sole identity, they could only approach the unknown in an instrumental relation to it.

Epistemic agents can engage in knowing and loving *only if* they do not feel the need to maintain their identity. This does not mean that they are not situated in a specific way, or that this situatedness does not shape their consciousness, but that they do not evaluate it as a fixed state. As Di Paolo(2005) notes, the adaptivity of organisms allows them to create new sets of values with the emergence of new functions, e.g. the ability for autonomous motor-action in animals. These new values extend the self and are non-revertible, “thus making the process irrevocable and resulting in the *coexistence of different identities in a same organism*.”(Di Paolo 2005). The feelings of the lived body constitute the unity of these identities as one active, embodied subject. The engagement required for the dynamic epistemical relation is given through the transformation of self and Umwelt through curiosity. It is the *absence* of feelings and emotions that makes the epistemic relation disfunctional. Therefore, emotions are necessary for epistemic action.

5. Conclusion

The distinction drawn above only serves to emphasize the dynamic nature of knowledge processes that De Jaegher lined out. Neither the instrumental nor the fearful relation to the unknown allow for this dynamic, and neither are neutral or unbiased, but reductive. In view of De Jaegher’s model, the epistemic function of curiosity can be determined. The formal object of curiosity is not truth if it is understood to consist in a correspondence of a fixed concept referencing a fixed factual state of affairs. Curiosity provides a different type of motivation. Through valuing the unknown as a formal object, curiosity creates the space of non-determination necessary for a dynamic epistemic relation. The desire for the unfolding of the other is a forceful incentive for an engaged “letting be”.

I intended to show in this text that a relevant regard in epistemology is not only the quality of the content of knowledge, but also the relation an epistemic agent enters into with that knowledge. Both the process and the product of knowledge gathering are significantly structured by the subject. Emotions and existential feelings play a large, irreplaceable part in structuring the epistemic process. Only emotions motivate epistemic agents to give full consideration to the unfolding of the epistemic object.

List of Abbreviations

KdU *Kritik der Urteilkraft (Critique of Judgment)*

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